Chapter Eighty-Nine

After Timurlane

Between 1401 and 1415,
Timur reconquers the Mongol empire,
and his heirs split it apart,
while the Ottomans fail to conquer
Constantinople

AFTER THE SACK OF DELHI, Timur had retreated to the cooler refuge of Samarkand, leaving the shattered Indian countryside to bake in the summer sun.

He was, before long, visited by an embassy from the Deccan. The sultan of the Bahmani kingdom, Firoz, had been awestruck by Timur's might; his ambassadors were even more floored by Samarkand itself. The city had been razed by Genghis Khan, its population slaughtered. But now it had risen from rubble back to splendid life. Timur's practice was to spare architects, artists, and craftsmen from execution and bring them back to his capital city to work there; in his hands, Samarkand had earned itself the nickname "Threshold of Paradise."

The Castilian diplomat Ruy González de Clavijo, visiting the city near the end of Timur's lifetime, wrote a detailed account of its wonders: salted through with mosques and minarets, paved courtyards and cobbled streets, green parks and marble houses. Timur had built a wide commercial street traversing the heart of the city with rows of shops on both sides, each shop